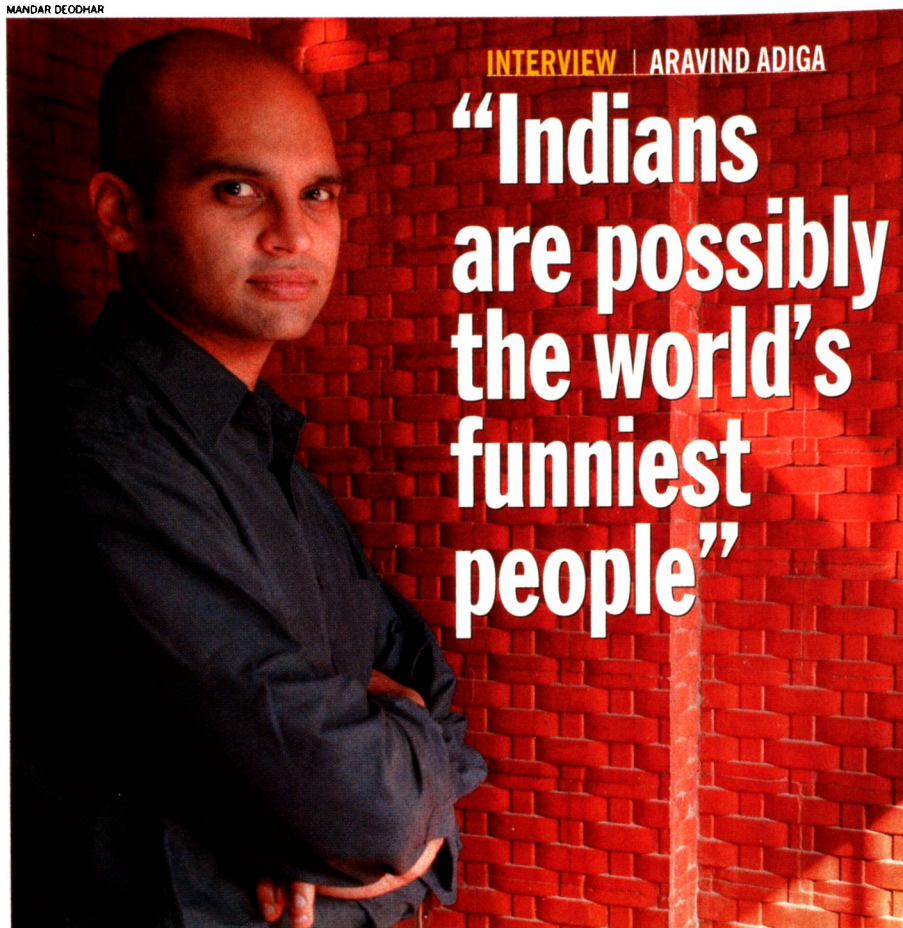


MANDAR DEODHAR



INTERVIEW | ARAVIND ADIGA

“Indians are possibly the world’s funniest people”

Aravind Adiga has become the third debutant to win the Booker Prize. On its way to victory, *The White Tiger* outpaced veterans like Salman Rushdie and Amitav Ghosh. The jury felt that the 33-year-old Adiga’s novel “shocked and entertained in equal measure”. He has dedicated the award to the people of Delhi. Excerpts from his conversation with Editor-at-Large S. PRASANNARAJAN.

Q. How thrilled are you?

A. I met Amitav Ghosh for the first time here, and that was a big thrill for me. He is modest, and charming, and I felt like a groupie going up to a rock star around him.

Years ago, when I was a student at Columbia University in New York, Ghosh was a professor there in the anthropology department, and I wanted to get his autograph—but I was too shy to do so. Finally I got to meet him! What a thrill.

Q. You still can’t believe it?

A. I couldn’t have done it without the support of so many reviewers in India—especially INDIA TODAY, which backed my novel early.

Q. Were you surprised by the sensational ride of *The White Tiger*?

A. Yes, since it’s a first time novel—and authors struggle to make an impact in today’s crowded literary scene.

Q. How are you taking in this sudden literary stardom?

A. Right now, I’m just doing lots of interviews!

Q. How much has your reporting career contributed to the making of this novel?

A. Working as a reporter for the *Time* magazine was a profoundly important experience as it gave me a chance to travel throughout India, especially north India—a new area for a boy born in Chennai and raised in Mangalore.

Q. Are you angry or disillusioned with the India you live in?

A. Anger is only one part of my reaction to the India I live in: also joy, love, acceptance and curiosity. There is nothing I like better than to get on to a train and travel through India. This is a novel and the narrator’s voice is different from the author’s.

Q. What provoked you to write about the underclass of the so called new India?

A. Too many men and women are invisible in today’s India—written out of our novels and films. They demand to be included in the literary scene.

Q. Can I call you a writer with a social conscience?

A. I think of myself as a novelist, a writer. I am not an activist at all.

Q. But you are ruthlessly un-sentimental about the social outcasts... You can be even funny.

A. Humour is a very important tool for any novelist. And Indians are, I think, possibly the world’s funniest people—it’s just that our television, films and books don’t adequately capture the venom, range, and intensity of the humour of our spoken language.

Q. What’s it like being a full-time writer?

A. It’s a very difficult thing to be a full-time writer; you are on your own—no staff, no colleagues, routine, etc. You live and die by discipline.

Q. What are you going to do with all this money?

A. Look for a safe, nationalised bank where I can deposit it all.

Q. What next?

A. Another book.

It’s a difficult thing to be a full-time writer; you are on your own then. You live and die by discipline.